

Manuscript Review & Decision Workflow

Plain-English recommendations for how a submitted paper moves from review to a final decision

What this is about

This is a simple summary of how a manuscript should travel through review after an author submits it, and the small changes I'm recommending so the system matches how we actually want reviewers and the managing editor to work together. I've kept it non-technical so it's easy to review and sign off on.

The manuscript journey (start to finish)

1. Author submits

The author uploads their paper and details. It lands in the editors' queue for a first look (“desk review”).

2. Editor assigns reviewers

The manuscript is sent to **3 reviewers** (an odd number, so votes rarely tie).

3. Reviewers review

Each reviewer reads the paper, writes their comments and corrections, and gives a recommendation: **Accept**, **Minor changes**, **Major changes**, or **Reject**.

4. Wait for all 3

The manuscript's status does **not** change until **all 3 reviewers have submitted**. No single reviewer can move it on their own.

5. Consensus is checked

Once all 3 are in, the system looks at whether they agree (the “consensus”) and prepares a suggested decision.

6. Managing editor decides

The managing editor makes the final call — always confirming the outcome, and especially when the reviewers don't clearly agree.

7. Author is notified

The author is told the outcome: accepted, changes requested, or declined — and the paper moves forward or is returned for corrections.

The three rules you asked for — and how we'd apply them

Your rule	What it means in practice
1. Decisions rest on a consensus of 3 reviewers	Every paper gets exactly 3 reviewers. The decision is based on whether they agree — not just on how many finished. Right now the system only counts reviews and ignores whether they say accept or reject.
2. The managing editor gives the final go-ahead when the vote isn't clear	When the 3 reviewers don't clearly agree (e.g. one says accept, one reject, one changes), it's automatically escalated to the managing editor to decide. The editor also confirms the clear cases, so nothing is fully automatic.

3. All reviewers submit their corrections before the status changes	The paper only moves to “changes requested” (or any next step) once all 3 have submitted. Today, any one reviewer can push it to “changes requested” immediately — we'd stop that.
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How we'd read the 3 votes

If the 3 reviewers say...	Suggested outcome
All 3 = Accept	Editor confirms Accept (fast-track)
All 3 = Reject	Editor confirms Reject
Any “changes”, or a majority for changes	Changes requested — sent back to the author (only after all 3 are in)
No clear winner (e.g. accept / reject / changes)	Escalate to managing editor for the final decision

What's different from today

- Today the paper advances after just **2** reviews — we'd require all **3**.
- Today the reviewers' actual votes (accept/reject) are **ignored** by the system — we'd use them to drive the decision.
- Today **one** reviewer can send a paper back for changes on their own — we'd wait until all 3 have submitted.
- If a reviewer drops out, we'd bring in a replacement so we always have 3 real reviews.

One thing to confirm: When the 3 reviewers clearly agree (all accept or all reject), should the system finalise it automatically, or should the managing editor still tick the final box? Best practice keeps the editor confirming every final decision — that's my recommendation — but it's your call, and it slightly changes how we build it.